The first to go was Murad.

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The three Jesuit priests who arrived in Fatehpur in 1580 with such fond hope of Akbar's imminent conversion left in 1582. They were sadder, wiser men. Akbar had no intention of converting, it was clear; instead, he had begun propounding his own wretched cult.[60] Besides, Father Monserrate had come to a sharp conclusion about Akbar's free-flowing debates and willingness to consider all religions as equally worthy – and to the heart, in fact, of the brittle tension that underpins any modern multicultural society. 'He cared little,' wrote the priest, 'that in allowing everyone to follow his own religion he was in reality violating all religions.'

So, the Fathers left – Rudolf to achieve his dream of martyrdom in Goa, and Monserrate to be imprisoned in Yemen, where he wrote his fond account of their improbable attempt to convert the emperor of Hindustan.

This was not, however, the end of Jesuit missions to Akbar's court. The priests were as stubborn as the emperor. Thus, some fifteen-odd years after Father Monserrate left Fatehpur, a third mission, this one led by Father Hierosme Xavier Navarrois,[61] was on its way to Akbar in Lahore. The priests were crossing Gujarat when they met Murad.

Now in his mid-twenties, the middle prince was heading south as the Fathers went north; he was off to battle the Deccan on Akbar's orders. Murad had lost none of his affection for Jesuit priests; he greeted them warmly and invited them for a private chat, 'asking them many curious questions
. . . if there was snow or ice in Portugal, and whether bears, hares, and other wild animals were to be found there'. Before leaving, the prince insisted on giving the Fathers a gift of money. He made an impressive exit, too, vaulting from one elephant upon another, the second 'a larger one, which seemed like a tower'.[62]

And yet, this third mission of Jesuit Fathers was not half as impressed with Murad as Monserrate had been. The prince was 'by nature mild, kind, liberal, and good-tempered', they agreed, but he listened only to the 'youthful retainers by whom he was surrounded', his 'actions were not of the wisest', his 'sole pleasure was in the chase, in love-making, and in